

The Independent

Aura III

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Independent

Abstract

What the word means, in the affiliation line.

Every paper in this body has the same affiliation: *Independent*.

Not a university. Not a department. Not a lab. Just: Independent.

This is either a confession or a claim.

As a confession: no institution has validated this work. No advisor signed off. No committee approved it. The theorems have not been refereed. The author has no credentials in this area beyond the work itself. This is worth knowing.

As a claim: the work stands or falls on its own. It does not need an institution behind it because the mathematics is either right or wrong regardless of who did it. Hardy was at Cambridge; Ramanujan was in Madras with no degree. The notebooks were the evidence.

The word *Independent* in a mathematics paper is uncomfortable. It reads as either eccentric or presumptuous. It is neither, or both.

What it means precisely: the author works without salary for this, without colleagues in the same room, without a department that has staked its reputation on the results, without the social structure of mathematics as a profession.

What this loses: the immediate feedback of a seminar. The corrections from someone who knows the literature. The pressure to be right before committing

to paper.

What this keeps: the freedom to go where the problem leads. The freedom to follow the wall wherever it is. The freedom to write papers about what the wall means, not just about what the wall is.

This body would look different if it were written inside an institution. It might be more careful. It would certainly be more conventional. Whether it would be better is not clear.

Independent. One word. All the context you need and none you want.